14.2 Bases

We use soaps for bathing as well as washing. Soaps are slippery in nature. Do you know why? Soaps are slippery due to the presence of 'base'. Bases are chemical substances that are corrosive and bitter in taste. A lot of bleaches, soaps, detergents, toothpaste, etc., contain bases. In contrast to acids which release hydrogen ions in water, bases release hydroxide ions in water.

Thus, the chemical substances that release hydroxide ions when dissolved in water are called as bases. Examples: Sodium hydroxide (NaOH) and Potassium hydroxide (KOH).

Sodium hydroxide $\xrightarrow{\text{Water}}$ Sodium ion + Hydroxide ion

$NaOH \xrightarrow{H_2O} Na^+ + OH^-$

Potassium hydroxide $\xrightarrow{\text{Water}}$ Potassium ion + Hydroxide ion

$KOH \xrightarrow{H_2O} K^+ + OH^-$

Water soluble bases are called Alkalis. Bases like sodium hydroxide, potassium hydroxide, calcium hydroxide and ammonium hydroxide are highly soluble in water and hence they are called alkalis. Certain chemical substances which do not release hydroxide ions when dissolved in water also behave as bases. Examples: Sodium carbonate, Sodium bicarbonate, Calcium carbonate etc.

Table 14.2 Common bases in some products

Base	Formula	Products
Magnesium hydroxide	$Mg(OH)_2$	Milk of magnesia
Sodium hydroxide	NaOH	Detergent
Ammonium hydroxide	NH_4OH	Solution for cleaning windows
Calcium hydroxide	$Ca(OH)_2$	Lime water
Potassium hydroxide	KOH	Soap



Sodium carbonate (Na_2CO_3) is commercially called as washing soda. Similarly sodium bicarbonate ($NaHCO_3$) is commercially called as baking soda. Caustic soda is sodium hydroxide (NaOH) and caustic potash is potassium hydroxide (KOH).

Activity 3

Classify the following substances.

Sodium oxide, Potassium hydroxide, Calcium oxide, Copper oxide, Calcium hydroxide, Ammonium hydroxide, Ferric hydroxide, Zinc oxide

Base	Alkali	Oxide

14.2.1 Properties of Bases

a. Physical properties

- Bases generally exist in solid state but some bases exist in liquid state also. E.g. Ammonium hydroxide, calcium hydroxide
- Bases give soapy touch only in aqueous medium not in dry nature.
- Bases are bitter in taste.
- Bases are corrosive in nature. When come in contact with the skin frequently they form painful blisters.
- Bases are generally colourless.
- Bases also change the colour of the indicators. Red litmus paper turns blue when treated with bases. Similarly, they turn methyl orange to yellow and phenolphthalein to pink colour.
- Bases also conduct electricity in aqueous solution.

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